

Application Exercise Design

Choosing an Appropriate Level of AI Use

For this lesson, I use three guiding questions to apply the AIAS: What outcomes are being assessed? What knowledge or skills must students demonstrate themselves? How could AI use strengthen or weaken the validity of the evidence? These questions operationalize the framework's emphasis on learning outcomes, student evidence, and assessment validity (Perkins et al., 2025).

Learning Objective

Objective 3: Apply three guiding questions to select and justify an AIAS level for a given assessment.

Scenario: The Client Recommendation

You teach a second-year course in a business diploma program. One of the major assessments asks students to analyze a realistic client scenario and submit a **1,200-word recommendation report**.

The purpose of the assessment is to determine whether students can:

- interpret incomplete and sometimes conflicting information;
- apply concepts from the course to a realistic situation;
- evaluate possible courses of action;
- justify a recommendation using evidence; and
- communicate that recommendation professionally.

Students have been asking whether they can use generative AI to help complete the report. You want your decision about AI use to reflect the purpose of the assessment rather than simply choosing between "AI allowed" and "AI prohibited."

Your team needs to consider the three guiding questions from the AI Assessment Scale:

1. What are the learning outcomes being assessed?
2. What specific skills or knowledge must the student demonstrate themselves?
3. How could AI use support or undermine the validity of the assessment?

Your Team's Decision

Which approach to AI use would BEST preserve the validity of this assessment while still allowing students to develop appropriate AI literacy?

- A. **No AI use:** Students may not use generative AI at any stage of the assessment. The instructor needs to know that every aspect of the analysis, recommendation, and final report was completed independently by the student.
- B. **AI for planning and idea development:** Students may use AI to brainstorm possible approaches, identify questions they should investigate, or develop an initial outline. The analysis, evaluation of evidence, recommendation, and written report must be completed by the student.
- C. **AI for planning, drafting, and revision:** Students may use AI to brainstorm, develop an outline, generate portions of the report, and revise their writing. Students remain responsible for checking the output, selecting appropriate evidence, and ensuring that the final recommendation is accurate.
- D. **Full AI collaboration:** Students may use AI throughout the assessment, including analyzing the client scenario, comparing possible solutions, generating recommendations, drafting the report, and revising the final submission. Students are responsible for the quality of the final product.

Team Task

Your team must select one option: A, B, C, or D.

Be prepared to defend your decision by answering: Which of the three guiding questions had the greatest influence on your decision, and why?

Facilitator Guide

B is the strongest choice.

The central purpose of this assessment is not simply to produce a professional-looking report. Students are being assessed on their ability to interpret information, apply course concepts, evaluate alternatives, and justify a recommendation.

Allowing AI to perform those cognitive tasks could make it difficult to determine whether the resulting work demonstrates the student's capabilities or the AI's capabilities.

At the same time, completely prohibiting AI is not necessarily required. Students could use AI during planning to generate possibilities, surface questions, or organize their initial thinking without outsourcing the core capabilities the assessment is intended to measure.

The key principle is assessment validity: AI use should not prevent the instructor from obtaining credible evidence that students have achieved the intended learning outcomes.

Why the other choices are plausible but less appropriate

- A. **No AI use** protects the validity of the assessment but may be unnecessarily restrictive. If brainstorming and planning are not themselves the capabilities being assessed, limited AI use at those stages may not interfere with the evidence the instructor needs.
- B. **AI for planning, drafting, and revision** introduces a significant validity concern. If AI generates portions of the analysis or argument, it becomes more difficult to determine whether students themselves can apply course concepts and construct a justified recommendation.
- C. **Full AI collaboration** would be appropriate only if effective collaboration with AI were itself an important learning outcome. In this scenario, AI could perform many of the exact cognitive processes the instructor is trying to assess.

How This Exercise Meets the TBL 4S Framework

Significant Problem: The team faces an authentic instructional decision rather than a recall question. Faculty increasingly need to determine not simply whether AI should be permitted, but where AI use supports learning and where it interferes with the evidence an assessment is intended to produce. The scenario therefore asks participants to apply the AI Assessment Scale to a consequential assessment-design problem.

Same Problem: Every team receives the same client-report scenario, the same learning outcomes, and the same four choices. Because teams work on an identical problem, their decisions can be directly compared during the whole-group discussion. Differences between teams become useful material for discussion rather than differences caused by teams having different cases.

Specific Choice: Every team must commit to exactly one choice: A, B, C, or D. Teams cannot respond with "it depends" or create their own hybrid solution. Even if team members see merit in multiple options, they must discuss the trade-offs and decide which option best preserves assessment validity while supporting appropriate AI use.

This forced choice is intentionally difficult. The quality of the exercise comes from the reasoning and debate required to reach the decision, not simply from identifying a predetermined correct answer.

Simultaneous Reporting: Once all teams have reached a decision, the facilitator asks them to reveal their choice at the same time using an A/B/C/D card, table tent, polling tool, or other simultaneous-response method. The facilitator can then immediately compare responses across the room: A | B | B | C | B | A

Rather than immediately announcing the recommended answer, the facilitator should use the variation between teams to generate discussion. Possible follow-up questions include:

- What is the key difference in your reasoning?
- Which learning outcome convinced you that drafting with AI would still provide valid evidence of learning?
- What would have to change about this assessment for D to become the best answer?
- Which of the three guiding questions helped your team eliminate an option?

What additional information about the assessment would be most likely to change your decision?